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CAT 125

28 April 2025

Personal Essay

From the Zoom meetings at Boeing to the crowded aisles of Home Depot, my journey has not been a traditional one. As a first-generation Latino college student, raised by resilient parents in a working-class household, I've always carried a strong sense of responsibility. Now, as I apply to UCSD's graduate program in computer science, I bring with me not only technical capabilities, but I come with the purpose to improve access to opportunities and amplify voices that would often not be heard.

Growing up, I was able to witness the quiet strength of my mother who managed three young kids and a home with care and resourcefulness, and the tireless work ethic of my father, who often left at 8 a.m. and returned late into the night. As the oldest, I stepped into a caretaker role early. I helped raise my siblings and tried to give them a joyful childhood despite our financial limitations. This meant taking on part-time jobs while in high school. My first job was at Chipotle, where I learned the value of kindness and efficiency. From there, I worked at Home Depot, where I discovered how customer service could be a powerful tool for connection. Many of the customers reminded me of my own family, especially the Spanish speaking elders. I did my best to bridge that gap, even with my limited Spanish.

My internship at Boeing was a pivotal turning point. I was able to acquire this internship during my senior year in High School. I managed a hypothetical \$60 million rocket launch project, developing cost models and proposing strategic solutions for cleaning up the orbital debris

plaguing earth. While I was able to enjoy the technical challenge, I was amazed by how rare it was to see someone who looked like me at the table. This led me to think more about the access to education and career paths, I learned I was privileged for this opportunity and I needed to make the most of it. At Boeing I realized how much impact a few lines of code could have, I wanted to make that impact and represent my community.

These jobs taught me more than responsibility, they grounded me in empathy, communication, and it gave me an awareness of the systematic challenges my community faces. When I arrived at UC San Diego, majoring in Mathematics and Computer Science, I noticed how rare it was to see Latinos in my classes. That realization inspired me to join Nu Alpha Kappa, a Latino-based fraternity rooted in brotherhood and community service. I wanted to be a part of the changes we make to our community so I became Community Service Chair and led initiatives from food drives to humanitarian efforts with Border Angels, supporting migrants along the border. I learned to coordinate these events and get a group motivated into participating in these events. These efforts are not just extracurriculars for me, it is something I believe can make an impact on a community that has given me so much.

Now, I want to pursue graduate study in computer science to deepen the technical skill I have learned at this University. I aim to focus on areas like software engineering, cybersecurity, and quantitative development. More than that, I want to build tools that serve the public, platforms that improve access to education, protect privacy, or help governments serve people more effectively. My goal is to ensure these systems are equitable and inclusive.

I may not be a legacy student and I do not come from generational privilege, but I carry with me the strength of my family, the lessons of my community, and the drive to shape a more diverse

future through technology. I believe graduate school is not just my next step academically, it is my next step to a career defined by purpose..